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REPORT ON REGISTRATION AND ORIENTATION EXERCISE AT MZUZU UNIVERSITY

Prepared for

The Vice Chancellor

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SUMMARY

The registration and orientation process for the new academic semester at Mzuzu University had some exercises performed like:

- Arrival of the new students
- Financial obligations
- Welcoming addresses
- Library orientation
- Campus touring
- Online registration process
- Medical examination process

The registration and orientation processes had well-structured aspects which may include:

- Information accessibility
- Timeliness

Registration and orientation process also had aspects that require improvement and these are:

- Venue for the orientation program
- Communication during welcoming addresses
- New online registration process
- Medical examination process

INTRODUCTION

The registration and orientation process at Mzuzu University which started on 29 January 2024, had both positive aspects and areas requiring improvement. While information accessibility on campus and timeliness during organization of different orientation and registration exercise were well done, there were issues with venue for orientation, communication during welcome addresses, new online registration process and medical examination process. Resolving these concerns would improve the overall experience for upcoming groups of new students. ICT Group 3 Students conducted interviews and research with some new students on the above stated aspects.

A) REGISTRATION AND ORIENTATION EXERCISE

During registration and orientation there were a lot of exercises that took place including, arrival of new students, financial obligation, welcome addresses, library orientation, campus tour, online registration process and medical examination. These exercises are further explained below.

1.Arrival of new students

On Monday, January 29th, both new face-to-face and ODL (Open and Distance Learning) undergraduate and postgraduate students arrived on campus. Upon their arrival, the office of the Dean of Students, in collaboration with the Office of Student Affairs, the Matron's Section, and Porters Lodge, meticulously organized the settling down process for these incoming students.

2. Financial obligation

As part of registration process, students were obligated to settle their financial responsibilities, including tuition fees, ID processing fees, medical examination fees, and student membership fees, through designated banking channels. These fees were deemed compulsory, ensuring that students fulfil their financial obligations before proceeding with their academic pursuits.

3. Welcome addresses

On Tuesday, 30th January, Codel complex served as a venue for the orientation of the incoming students. Mr. Yonamu Ngwira, the University Registrar, extended a warm welcome to the new comers, imparting insightful remarks to set the tone for their academic journey. Additionally, a representative from Malawi police stationed in Luwinga offered valuable insights on matters pertaining to campus safety and security, ensuring a conducive environment for both academic pursuits and personal well-being within the precincts of Mzuzu city.

4. Library orientations

The librarian, Mr. Felix Majawa oriented new students on how to access library and learning resources during the library tour on Thursday, 1 February. This made the new students to familiarize themselves with the resources available in library.

5. Campus tour

The Mzuzu University Representative Council (MUSREC) conducted an extensive campus tour for new students, encompassing the main campus along with Codel and Dunduzu. This comprehensive initiative aimed to provide incoming students with a holistic understanding of the university's diverse facilities and resources across various locations.

6. Online registration process

Mr. Enock Tung'ande, from ICT Directorate, led the effort to make it easier for new students to register online for the new Integrated Management Information System (IMIS). This was done to help incoming students with their registration process.

7. Medical examination

This particular exercise is mandatory component of the registration process, it was administered to new students on the final day of orientation at the University Clinic by the clinical officer, Mr. Christopher Mwenegamba.

B) WELL STRUCTURED ASPECTS

i. Information accessibility

Mr. Clive Chinkhuntha, one of the new students explained that new students were promptly informed about designated venues for orientation and registration activities via the program of events memorandum disseminated by the Mzuzu University administration. He further emphasized that this facilitated comprehensive understanding among students regarding precise timing allocated for each event.

ii. Timeliness

The orientation and registration exercises were meticulously arranged and executed in timely manner. According to Mr. Clive who highlighted that the program of events memorandum distributed by the Mzuzu University comprehensively outlined the schedule for the entire orientation and registration proceedings. This facilitated seamless organization, as both presenters and students adhered punctually to their respective roles and adhered strictly to the predetermined time frame delineated in the program of events.

C) ASPECTS THAT REQUIRE IMPROVEMENT

i. Venue for the orientation program

During the orientation program at Codel complex, there was a lack of chairs, which resulted in some students having to stand. This created an inconvenience and discomfort for those who couldn't find a seat. It would have been better if the University had organized enough chairs to accommodate all the students attending the program.

ii. Communication during welcoming addresses

During the orientation process, there were significant communication barriers that affected the effectiveness of the welcoming addresses. According to Miss Annette Banda, she emphasized that there was excessive background noise which made it difficult for students to hear the speakers clearly. She also added that microphones used were not audible enough to overcome the noise, resulting in a lack of comprehension and engagement among the students.

iii. The new online registration processes

Implementation of a new online registration process brought about several challenges for students. After conducting the research and interview with some new students and some ccontinuing students respectively. It was found that one of the major problems was the frequent system failure. The online registration system was constantly being updated, which resulted in technical glitches and disruptions during the registration period. Students encountered error messages, slow loading times, and even complete system crashes, causing frustration and delays in the registration process. Additionally, another issue arose due to a shortage of ICT experts assisting with the online registration. With limited personnel available to address technical issues and provide support, students faced difficulties in resolving their registration problems promptly.

iv. The medical examination processes

After conducting the research and interview with some new students both face-to-face and ODL postgraduate and undergraduate student. It was found that medical examination process faced significant challenges due to the absence of a specific schedule for different faculties or programs. As a result, the clinic became overcrowded with students, leading to inefficiencies and delays. Without a clear schedule, students from various faculties would flock to the clinic at the same time, causing long waiting times and overcrowding in the waiting area. This not only created inconvenience for students but also put a strain on the clinic staff.

RECOMMENDATIONS

ICT Group 3 students recommends that various aspects that need improvements can be addressed in various ways. Firstly, when it comes to the venue for the orientation program, consider selecting a spacious location that can accommodate all the participants comfortably, with proper seating arrangements and good audiovisual facilities. Secondly, enhancing communication during welcoming addresses can be achieved by using effective visual aids, engaging speakers, and providing written materials to reinforce key information. Additionally, for the new online registration process, make sure to provide clear instructions and user-friendly interfaces to ensure a smooth and hassle-free experience for students. Lastly for the medical examination process it would be beneficial to establish a well-organized schedule that allocates specific time slots for different faculties or programs. By implementing these recommendations, the Mzuzu University can improve the overall experience for students and ensure a successful and well-organized process.

CONCLUSION

The report highlighted both well-structured aspects and area that required improvement. The aspects that were well structured included the accessibility of information and timeliness of the programs. However, they were areas that needed improvement, such as the medical examination process, the new online registration process, the venue for the orientation program, and the lack of effective communication during orientation process. The report suggests implementing measures to enhance these areas and ensure a more seamless and efficient orientation and registration experience.

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